

ANTEATERS, SLOTHS AND ARMADILLOS



A BIZARRE GROUP of animals make up the order of mammals known as the edentates. They include the anteaters, armadillos, and sloths, all of which, except the nine-banded armadillo, live in the tropical regions of South and Central America. The name "edentate" means "without teeth", but it is a misleading term, as only the anteaters are toothless. In fact, some armadillos have more teeth than any other land mammal.

Tongue

Anteaters have long sticky tongues that can be pushed deep into termite nests. The tongue is covered in little spines that point backwards, making it very difficult for ants and termites to escape.



Curved spines on tongue

Giant anteater breaking into a termite mound.



Long bushy tail

Giant anteater

Young

A female anteater gives birth to a single young. The young anteater travels on its mother's back for the first year of its life, by which time it is almost half the size of its mother.



Anteater

There are four species of anteater. The giant anteater lives in grasslands; the other three species live in forests and have prehensile (grasping) tails with which they hang from trees. Anteaters have long snouts and tongues to enable them to collect the termites and ants on which they feed. They locate their prey with their acute sense of smell. Their foreclaws are so large that they need to walk on their knuckles. The claws are used to break open termite nests and for defence. If threatened, they rear up on their hind legs and try to rip their opponent with their claws.

Armadillo

Of the 21 species of armadillo, the largest is the giant armadillo, which is 91.5 cm (3 ft) in length. It has up to 100 peg-like teeth – twice as many as most mammals – which are shed when the animal reaches adulthood. The smallest species, the fairy armadillo, is less than 15 cm (6 in) long. Armadillos give birth to up to four young. The nine-banded armadillo, from North America, gives birth to quadruplets of the same sex.

Claws

Armadillos have large curved claws. They use them to dig into the ground to make burrows, to escape predators, and to find food. The giant armadillo's middle claw is the largest claw in the animal kingdom, measuring 18 cm (7 in) around the curve.



Nine-banded armadillo

Bony plates



Large claws

Hairy stomach

Nine-banded armadillo

Body armour

Armadillos are encased in "body armour" formed by separate plates made of bone. Soft skin links the plates together, giving them flexibility. In most species the plates cover only the upper part of the body. If threatened, some species, such as the three-banded armadillo, roll into a ball, while others make for their burrow or dig themselves into the ground.



Sloth

Adapted to living upside down, sloths hang by their claws from the branches of trees. They can rotate their heads through a 270° angle, allowing them to keep their head upright while their body remains inverted. They eat, mate, give birth, and spend their entire life-cycle upside down. Sloth's hair lies in the opposite direction from other animals', to allow rain to run off. Only when asleep do they adopt a more normal position, by squatting in the fork of a tree. There are seven species of sloth; all are herbivorous.



Female three-toed sloth with baby

Green algae cover the sloth's coat.

Movement

Sloths are very slow movers. They rarely descend to the ground as they can only just stand, but cannot walk. They drag themselves along with their claws. In water though, they are good swimmers.



Sloth swimming

Camouflage

Due to the high humidity levels in the rainforest, infestations of green algae grow within a sloth's fur and cover its coat. This acts as a camouflage and makes the sloth less conspicuous. As the seasons change, the algae change colour to match the colour of the trees.

Pangolin

There are seven species of pangolin, or scaly anteater. They have much in common with the edentates, but they belong to a different order called the Pholidota. They are covered with scales attached to the skin. Some species have a long, prehensile tail that is used to grasp branches and also to lash out at predators. They feed on termites, ants, and larvae which they catch with their long tongues.



Malayan pangolin

GIANT ANTEATER

SCIENTIFIC NAME

Myrmecophaga tridactyla

ORDER

Edentata

FAMILY

Myrmecophagidae

DISTRIBUTION

South America

HABITAT

Grasslands and savannahs

DIET

Termites, ants, and larvae

SIZE

Length, including tail: 1.83 m (6 ft)

LIFESPAN

25 years (in captivity)

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